



are believed to speak at least 60 dialects.

Bartholomew was still an adolescent when he dropped out of high school to become a roving photographer. He was in his 30s when he started work on *The Nagas*. His prize-winning career has spanned several watershed events of our nation such as the Bhopal gas tragedy, anti-Sikh riots and the Babri demolition. Now, at 66, he says photography for him was never just the one thing: "It was a combination of many things—interest, desire, an escape vehicle, therapy, compulsion and necessity." ■

–Shaikh Ayaz

PHOTOGRAPHY

Through the Lens, Clearly

Vinay Sheel Oberoi's photos of the Monpa people bring us closer to an otherwise distant community

Posted in the Northeast after qualifying for the Indian Administrative Service in 1979, the late Vinay Sheel Oberoi's initial, chance connection with the region grew into a great love. Told through a collection of over 250 photographs, and accompanied by an informative and expressive eight-chapter text, *Monpas: Buddhists of the High Himalayas*, Oberoi's 200-page documentation of the people and their place, the Kameng region of Arunachal Pradesh, is the result of journeys both big and small, of serendipitous moments that spanned decades.

Documenting the life of a people is not an easy task, especially when the community is both distinct and distant from the 'mainstream'. The idea for the book crystallised after an exhibition in 2018 in Delhi. Once the photographs had been displayed at the India International Centre, the exhibition travelled to the place where it all started—Tawang, Arunachal Pradesh. The process of bringing it all together began when Roli Books decided to publish the photos as a book. Sadly, Oberoi passed away in April 2020.

As the introduction explains, "These were travels for more than a few reasons: a reconnaissance for a film in the making (yet to be made), an expedition to where my wife lived as a child [her father had been posted there in 1962 as an officer in the Indian Frontier Administrative Service], a trip to investigate temperate and monopodial bamboo, and a memorable series of visits for motor rallies. The list grew longer and more varied; any and every opportunity would do." These, along with a growing interest in photography, however, might not have been quite enough had Oberoi not also been gifted with an eye for the unusual, an ear for stories and a historian's ability to stitch together narratives.

The book is a gentle and luminous look into the life of a very special people, their habitat, culture and traditions. Even as Oberoi observed the landscapes shifting with the change in seasons, he forged many connections with the people there: "It was a glorious afternoon in Dirang and the sun shone brilliantly across the valley. I sat with a village elder as he ruminated on days gone by. Every so often, he would take a sip of arrah, freshly made and still warm. 'When I was young,' he said wistfully, 'Monpa houses were made of timber, bamboo and stone. Not a nail, not a glass window.'"

In an effort to preserve a centuries-old craft, mastered only by a few families in the village of Mukto, Oberoi, who had also worked with UNESCO in Paris, had even tried to set up a handmade paper (traditionally used for scriptures and monastic records) unit. A single sheet of this paper has been included in the book.

In his foreword, His Holiness the 14th Dalai Lama speaks of "the knowledge of *ahimsa* and *karuna* that so strongly permeate Monpa culture". Our increasingly fractured world would do well to listen. ■

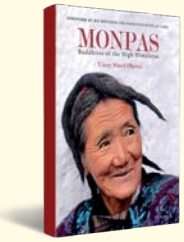
–Elizabeth Eapen

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MONPAS
Buddhists of the High Himalayas
by Vinay Sheel Oberoi
ROLI BOOKS
₹2,995; 200 pages



▲ **Documenting Monpa culture** (from top) a couple drinking *chhang*; and a performance of the yak dance